THE TRANS SAHARAN TRADE

The Trans Saharan trade was the trade that was carried out between the North African Berbers and the western African Negroes across the Sahara Desert. The Trade linked the two geographical regions of North Africa and west Africa having people of north Africa, the savanna and the forest regions of west Africa.

It was initiated by the Berbers and the Africans who were later joined by the Arabs, Jews and the Romans. The greatest participants were the Berbers, Tuaregs and the western African Negroes (Africans).

It was between the west Africans occupying the land of Bilad es' sudan (the land of black people) and the north African Berbers.

It is not clear when the trade begun but according to Christopher Fyfe, the trade might have started many 1000 (thousand) years before our era. Its growth was gradual and it lasted between 300-1600 AD that is, during the 4th-17th century.

It was a dumb /silent trade because the traders did not understand each other's' language.

From North Africa, the basic commodity was salt and gold from West Africa respectively. Barter trade was used and Arabic language was later used as the medium of communication.

THE ORIGINS OF THE TRANS SAHARAN TRADE.

1. The Trans Saharan trade was the trade between the **North African Berbers** and the **West African Negroes across the Sahara Desert.** It was called so because it was carried out across the Sahara Desert before the Christian era but this can be debated.
2. It was carried out between the North Africa Berbers and the West African Negroes (of Western Sudan) It was initiated / begun by the North Africa Berbers and the West Africa Negroes. These were later joined by the Arabs, Jews, Tuaregs and Phoenicians.
3. The Trans Sahara Trade begun as a dumb/ silent trade because of the language barrier and The trade started out of the demand for certain goods on both ends of North Africa and West Africa.

4. Gold from West Africa and salt from North Africa were the basic items in this trade. Salt was needed by the Negroes in West Africa and it was mined in North Africa.
5. Other goods from West Africa were; Ostrich feathers, ivory, slaves, Kola nuts among others. Other essential goods from North Africa needed in West Africa included beads, fruits, glass etc.
6. The volume of the Trans Saharan trade was small at the beginning. The trade increased in volume with the introduction of Camels as means of transport by the Berbers.

7. The initial transport used was head porter age, Ox-drawn Carts/ Chariots and Horses. Camels later became the basic means of transport across the Sahara Desert.

8. However, the views on the Origin and dates of when the Trans Sahara Trade begun is not clear. However, **Christopher Fyfe** argues that the trade might have started many thousand years ago before our era (1000 B.C). This was as early as about the first and 2nd centuries.

9. It followed **the Roman occupation** of North Africa and this is what led to the exploration across the Sahara. The trade gained pace around the 3rd century and 4th century towards the introduction of the Camels.
10. The trade boomed following the Arab conquest and settlement in North Africa. This made the Berbers to migrate and settle into the Sahara terminals. By then, it was about the 2nd and 3rd century.
11. It was initially conducted on barter trade terms/system and Originally, there were no trade routes but later got developed.

THE FACTORS FOR THE GROWTH / DEVELOPMENT OF THE TRANS SAHARAN TRADE

1. The factors for the development of the trade were many/diverse. These factors were social, political and economic in nature;

2. **The Arab conquest of north Africa** in the 7thcentury led to its development, it made the Berbers to migrate to the desert Oasis and settle in the sudan cities hence increasing the volume of trade.
3. **The spread of Islam in west Africa** (western sudan) made the trade to prosper as it brought ideal conditions of justice. **The Islamic religion also brought unity** (brotherhood) among the people of in West Africa for the trade to take place. The moslem scholars/ clerics were at times traders themselves, these scholars helped to advertise the trade in west Africa and even abroad.
4. **The trade also developed rapidly due to the introduction of Camels in the 3-4 B.C**. The camels revolutionized transport across the Sahara. The camels were better because they were more adaptable to the harsh desert conditions. The camels could also go for long without taking water and their feet could walk in the sand in the desert.

5. **The availability of the highly demanded (basic goods**) in the trade i.e Gold from western Sudan and salt from north Africa made it to develop.There were also **other essential commodities** from the south (west Africa) like ostrich feathers, kola nuts, ivory, food stuffs etc which facilitated the trade. From the north africa, there were other essential goods like dates, oliveoils, swords, guns, beads, horses etc which expanded the trade.

6. **The availability of market (demand) for the goods** in both north Africa and west Africa made it to prosper.
7. **The rise of western Sudanic empires** like Ghana, Mali, Songhai and others led to its development. These states and the west African kings(chiefs) like Mansa Musa and Askia Mohammed- the great led to the growth of trade, leaders mobilized their subjects for trade
8. **The west African kings (chiefs) also ensured security for the traders** from north Africa and this gave a new impetus to the trade across the Sahara.
9. **The introduction of Arabic language in west Africa helped** to solve the language barrier (problem) in the business.
10. **The development of caravan routes across the Sahara** for the trade led to its growth, they included the western route, central, the eastern route and many others.
11. **The presence of resting places and Oasis in the desert enabled the supply** of water and food for both the visitors and their camels.
12. **The efficient organization of the Berbers in the trade** was **instrumental** in its development, they organized caravans, financed business and employed Tuaregs as guides and guards.
13. The Africans equally played a part in its development, they supplied visitors with items like Gold, kola nuts, water and food. The Tuaregs played a role in its growth, they worked as security guards for the traders, guided the caravans and cleaned the Oasis.
14. The presence of trust worth system among the traders (both the Berbers and the Africans) made the trade to expand and the trade was profitable to all the parties in the business hence it had to expand.
15. **The introduction of cowrie shells, Gold and copper bars** helped to solve the problems of barter trade. They worked as medium of exchange in the trade.
16. For many centuries, **the trans Saharan trade was un rivalled** and was the major economic activity.it expanded and went as far across the Mediterranean Sea, middle east and southern Europe.

Camels/Transport Caravan with goods from North Africa

THE ORGANISATION OF THE TRANS SAHARAN TRADE

Qn. How was the trans Saharan trade organized?

1. The trans Saharan trade was organized across the sahara desert and it was between the North African Berbers and the west African Negroes. The most prominent traders in this trade were the Berbers, Arabs, the Negroes(Africans), Europeans and the Jews.

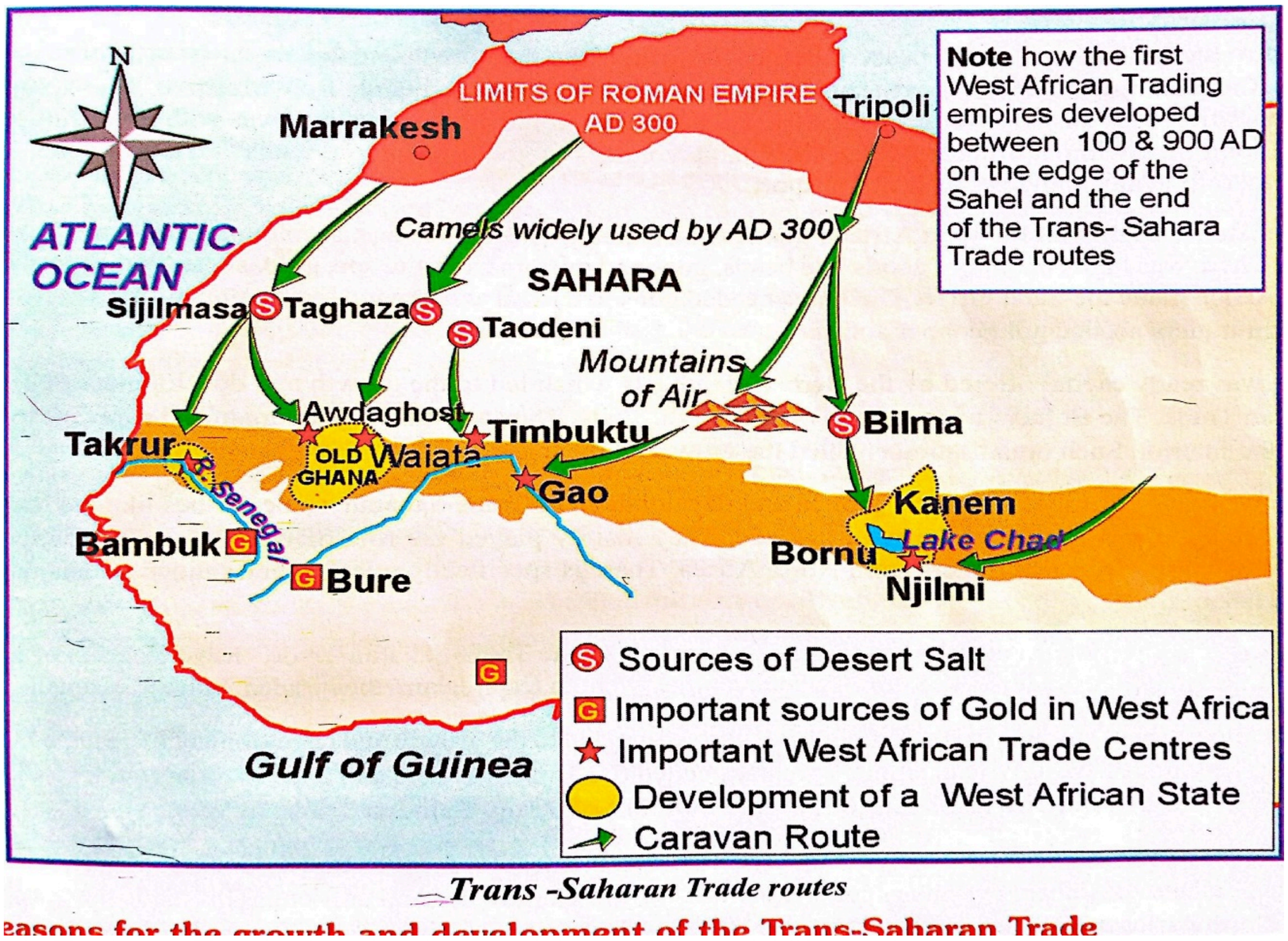
2. It was organized and controlled by the Berber merchants of North Africa who provided capital and organized trade caravans across the desert from north Africa. The Berbers also employed the Tuaregs as guides to the wells and pastures. they were to also guard the caravans of the Berbers.
3. The west African Negroes played the searcher mans' role by providing the trade items to the Berbers, the offered hospitality to them and gave them food and water.

4. The Tuaregs on the other hand, lived in and knew the vast sahara desert so they were used as guides to the caravans in these places. They worked as guards and cleaned the Oasis in return for payment from the Berbers.
5. They north Africa Berbers met at specific places and then left for south in large groups (caravans) of about 1000 at the end of the rainy season. The caravan traders from north Africa brought highly demanded items such as salt that was most important and valuable import to west Africa. It was mined from Taghaza, Taoden and Bilma.

6. The North Africa Berbers also brought in other essential items to west Africa like Dates, Olive oils, guns, swords and Horses.
7. The west African Negroes supplied the north Africa visitors with Gold as a basic item. It was mined from the regions of upper volta, upper Senegal and wangara. The Africans also sold other items like slaves highly demanded in south west Asia for house hold, kola nuts, ostrich feathers, ivory and food stuffs.
8. **At first, the acceptable medium of exchange was barter** because goods were exchanged for goods. However, the traders later introduced cowrie shells, Gold coins and copper bars to work as medium of exchange besides the Iron coinage. The trade was based on mutual/ trust ship basis as the Berbers entrusted their loans and goods to the west African negroes for business.

9. Initially, the transport system used in the trade was head **porterage, oxen and horses. However, later in the 4th century, they introduced and used donkeys** and Camels that were more adaptable to the desert conditions.

10. It was initially a silent /dumb trade because the traders did not understand each other's' language. **However, as time went on, they introduced Arabic language** and this was used as medium of communication.
11. **The trans Saharan traders used 6-7 caravan routes** running from north Africa to West Africa, they included the western route, the central route, the eastern route, the transcontinental route and others;
12. **The Taghaza-Timbuctu or western route**. This route begun from sijilmasa in Morocco



Trans -Saharan Trade routes

Reasons for the growth and development of the Trans-Saharan Trade

passed via Taghaza, Taodeni and walata and then went to old Ghana, jenne

13. and Timbuctu.It was important for Gold and salt trade.
14. **The Central route-Ghadames-air** started from Tunis and passed through Ghadames, Ghat and Agades to katsina and kano in Hausand
15. **The Fezzan-kawar or eastern route** begun from Tripoli and Egypt and passed through Fezzan, Tibest, kawar and Bilma to lake Chad area (Bornu), it was important for salt and slaves.
16. **The Trans- continental route** ran from Egypt via kufra oasis south wards to kano.

THE ROLE OF DIFFERENT GROUPS IN THE TRANS SAHARAN TRADE.

The Africans;

a) The Africans provided most of the export items needed in the north Africa for example Gold, ivory, hides and skins, kola nuts and ostrich feathers,
b) They acted as recipients of the goods from north Africa e.g dates and horses.
c) The Africans also organized the market centres which worked as trading centres for the traders in west Africa such as jenne, walata, Gao, Timbuctu and others.
d) The African kings (chiefs) provided security along the trade routes in the empires and Gold bearing areas.
e) The Africans also provided food, water and accommodation to the traders from north Africa.
f) Some Africans acted as middle men between the north Africa Berbers and the west African Negroes.

THE BERBERS

a) The Berbers controlled the trade before the Arab massive involvement in the sahara.
b) The Berber merchants organized the caravans from north Africa to west Africa.
c) The Berbers were also middlemen between the Arabs and the west African Negroes.
d) The Berbers provided capital(finance) for the merchants in the trade i.e they acted as tycoons and money lenders.
e) Berbers employed the Tuaregs as guides and guards across the sahara.
f) They controlled the salt trade that was highly demanded in west Africa.
g) They brought goods from north Africa demanded in west Africa such as dates, horses, beads and clothes.
h) They encouraged many Africans to convert to Islam in order to creat unity for business.

The Tuaregs

a) The Tuaregs were normads who lived as desert dwellers, they knew every inch of the vast and monotonous sahara desert so they were employed by the Berbers as guides along the caravan routes.
b) They provided security to the traders along the caravan routes
c) They were hired to guard the desert Oasis and resting places.
d) Tuaregs cleared the trade routes as they worked as patrol units
e) They kept the Oasis clean

The Arabs

a) The Arabs encouraged slave raiding among the African communities.

b) The Arabs also brought in camels as a means of transport for the trade, that why the trade increased in volume in the 3rd –4th century BC**.**

PROBLEMS/DIFFICULTIES FACED BY THE TRANS SAHARAN TRADERS

a) In the course of the trade, the trans Saharan traders faced many problems before 1500 and these were social, political and economic in nature.
b) They faced harsh desert conditions in that there was extreme heat during day and bitter/chilly or cold nights.
c) There was language barrier at first because the Berbers and the Africans did not understand each other's' language.
d) There were heavy sand storms that could sometimes block the trade routes.
e) They faced heavy taxes from the local African chiefs of western Sudan.
f) The traders journey was un necessarily too long, it could take about 2-3 months.
g) **Flies** and **wild animals like scorpions and the snakes** in the desert and west Africa were abig problem.
h) There **were poor storage facilities** for the trade goods as some could always go bad before being sold.
i) Traders lacked compasses for direction and they could always lose their trade terminals.
j) Some Tuaregs always misled the traders deliberately hence a problem.
k) There was poor means of transport and communication.
l) The Sahara Desert was very vast (big) for the traders to cross it.
m) There was no uniform standards of weights and measures. This could lead to cheating of some traders some times.
n) There was shortage of accommodation facilities as traders were on transit.
o) Barter trade had its own draw backs for example the value of Gold was not necessarily equivalent to that of Salt.
p) There were inter-state wars/political instability which affected the trading activities in west Africa, some traders were killed.
q) There was shortage of food and water because west Africa was sparsely populated in the desert.
r) The traders later faced stiff competition from other traders like those of the Trans-Atlantic trade.
s) There was lack of proper currency used in the trade.
t) There was the problem of double coincidence of needs(wants).
u) Traders faced high interest rates charged on the loans given to them. This made them to have losses.
v) Some Agents in west Africa were corrupt and not trust worthy because some inherited the goods they were told to buy.

WHY THE TRANS-SAHARAN TRADE DECLINED.

Qn. What factors led to the decline of the Trans Saharan trade?

1. The factors for the decline of the Trans Saharan trade were many. These factors were social, political and economic in nature. The reasons for this predicament were both internal and external. It was a gradual process of declining and it started in about the 16th and the17th century, the decline was accomplished in the 20th century (1912)

POLITICAL FACTORS

2. The decline of the trans Saharan trade was triggered off by the Moroccan invasion of Songhai accelerating the empires' decline and consequently reducing the volume of the trade on the western route. **According to Garrard**, the Gold export to North Africa considerably fell from 24000kg. to 1400 kg because of the instability. The **Moroccan invasion of Songhai** also forced the commercial activities to shift to central and eastern routes.

3. The trade also declined due to the fighting for the control of the remnants of trade by the Moroccans, Songhai and Fulani.
4. **The outbreak of the Turko-Italian wars in 1912** created instability hence reducing the volume of trade.
5. **The European colonization of West Africa decampaigned** the business for legitimate trade by opening up the Kano-Lagos line in 1912.

SOCIAL-ECONOMIC FACTORS

6. **The discovery of the Trans-Atlantic trade** led to the decline of the Trans Saharan trade because it was shorter, safer and faster compared to the trans Saharan trade. **The trade increased European commercial activity** at the coast of west Africa from the 15th century and this shifted the African attention to the coast hence leading to the decline of the trans Saharan trade.
7. **The discovery of the sea route via the Mediterranean Sea** meant that goods would be cheaply carried to the northern markets by sea than across the Sahara Desert. This route also brought in cheaper goods like salt, cloth, food stuffs and weapons which de-campaigned the trans Saharan trade goods from the 17th century.
8. **The Christian missionary advance slave trade** hence robbing the Trans Saharan trade one of its principle commodity in the 19th century. It was because the slave labour which was used to guard the desert Oasis had been abolished.

9. **The Discovery of Gold deposits in Latin America and south Africa** lessened the demand for the gold trade in west Africa.

10. **The exhaustion of goods**, some goods required for trade got exhausted by 1820s for example gold, salt and slaves.

THE CONSQUENCES / RESULTS OF THE TRANS SAHARAN TRADE

1. The results of the trans Saharan trade were quite many and far reaching; political, social, religious and economic in nature and They were both positive and negative but largely positive.

POLITICAL RESULTS

2. **The trade led to the rise and expansion of states and empires** in west Africa. these included Ghana, Mali, Songhai, Asante due to the wealth they acquired from trade. This led to the emergence of powerful rulers (statesmen) in the Sudan. they included Tunka manin, Mansa Musa, Sunni Ali and Askia Mohammed I and others.

3. The trade led to the growth of trading centres and market centres in west Africa for example **Timbuctu, walata, Kano, Gao, Jenne** and others.
4. The importation of fire arms and Horses from the north helped to strengthen the west African armies and cavalries. Such Armies were instrumental in the imperial expansion of states, they ensured law, order and defence as well.

SOCIAL RESULTS

5. The **trade led to the spread of Islam in western sudan**. The muslim Berbers and Arabs traded while spreading Islam.The above led to the establishment of Muslim schools and mosques e.g in Timbuctu and Jenne.

6. It led to the penetration of west Africa by the Arab /muslim influences (cultures) for example the dress code, prayers, Hijja, fasting and muslim education. The Arabic architecture of building using burnt bricks, building Dome shaped houses. The d**ome** shaped and decorated houses were adopted by the Africans in west African.

7. Similar, the Arabic language was introduced and used as lingua-franca, It was widely used in schools and preaching. **This led to the employment of literate Moslems** to work in offices as clerks, secretaries, good advisors, interpreter's lawyers and teachers.

8. It **led to intermarriages** between the North Africa Berbers, Arabs and the Africans leading to the birth of mixed Negroid races like the **Arma, Fulani, th**e **Hausa and the Kanembu**, It led to the emergence of 2(two) Social classes of people in west Africa that is the Resident foreign merchants and the local professional traders for example the, Wangara**, Dyula and the Mande** speaking people.

9. The trade helped to link up west Africa and north to the Arab world (the outside world).

ECONOMIC RESULTS

10. It led to the introduction of new currencies in West Africa for example cowrie shells, manilas, copper bars and Gold coins.
11. The trade **improved on the peoples 'standard of living** because of the introduction of essential goods like spices, food, salt and others.
12. **It led to the introduction of slave trade** and its associated evils like **suffering and depopulation**.
13. The enslavement of non-Muslim Africans led to animosity between Muslims and non-Muslims hence causing social order. The sale of Africans into slavery marked the beginning of trans- Atlantic slave trade.
14. The participants became wealthy (rich) especially the middlemen and the African chiefs and kings.